even espousers of free-market virtues are prepared to give their principles a short shrift. Security assessments, therefore, now require a comprehension of how dependencies are created and exploited. There is also an understandable trend among polities with greater security consciousness to scrutinize investment inflows and business takeovers.

On top of all this is the now increasingly recognized power of big tech companies, whose market capitalization often exceeds the GDP of nations. This is not just about the mammoth size of the relevant enterprises. Nor is it necessary to enter a debate about the politics and ethics of their influence. As realists, we can be neither oblivious to their relevance in our daily life nor impervious to the outcomes that they can help influence. Concerns about privacy and commerce have now mutated into something much larger. We are used to State and non-State actors. But enterprises with their own mega-interests are breaking new ground in modern international relations.

The problem that society at large faces is that these enterprises seek to work on their own agenda and norms. Moreover, recent events have underlined that even strong States find it tough to fully gauge, leave alone control, enterprises of this scale. Such entities can even provide capabilities that are normally associated with governments or stake out their own line of geopolitics. Businesses betting against governments and nations is not new in itself. But the manner in which they do so has been facilitated by our way of life. We cannot be blind to these winds of change.

WAR BY OTHER MEANS

It can be justifiably argued that every society’s understanding of security matures, whether spatially or otherwise. Distant threats became more real and imminent as mobility improved. Those who mastered such techniques on an impactful scale became dominant; the rest were their victims.

We, in India, of course know it as part of the Panipat syndrome and, thereafter, the colonial experience. History offers many telling examples elsewhere. The modern era, however, has taken this to a completely different level. For, in effect, globalization and technology have, between them, erased distances and, thereby, create unprecedented challenges.

The old way was to contemplate military capabilities or coercive acts that were instrumental in creating outcomes, balances and influence. Even